

eCTD Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

FAQs

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Why is ICH implementing eCTD v4.0 instead of continuing to update eCTD v3.2.2?

- eCTD v3.2.2 is hardcoded and cannot be responsive to changes in the CTD (i.e., requires a DTD update), which required the need for a new major version
- The primary focus is the implementation of eCTD v4.0 across all regions to incorporate new requirements instead of adding them to the existing eCTD v3.2.2
- The implementation of eCTD v4.0 has already started in major regions and is ongoing
- Updates for the regional implementation plans and timelines are available at the ICH website
- Implementation of eCTD v4.0 is the foundation for future developments and enhancements to eCTD
- ICH M8 agreed to defer all CTD changes to eCTD v4.0 implementation. Any new requirements are incorporated into eCTD v4.0 e.g., ICH M4Q(R2)

What are the most meaningful benefits of eCTD v4.0?

- Document reuse, this allows reuse of content (via UUIDs) across applications, independently of how submissions are stored at the agency. Allows ability to reuse data across different applications and regulatory bodies significantly reduce redundancy and workload on the regulator and industry side
- Updates on process and specification are managed via controlled vocabularies; eCTD v3.2 updates require a new DTD version causing version management challenges
- Correction of metadata (attributes, keywords) possible
- Change of document granularity/life cycle (one-to-many, many-to-one)
- Grouping of documents (via Group Title keywords) and document ordering (via Priority Numbers)
- The structure of eCTD 4.0 allows for more streamlined and efficient submission processes (e.g., one XML exchange message)

Why is the eCTD v4 implementation based on HL7 v3 RPS?

- ICH M2 and M8 EWG analyzed the impact of limited HL7 support for RPS and concluded this as acceptable and manageable (i.e., any new requirements could be handled by a manual authoring process)
- The content in the CTD needs to be standardised and regulatory submission processes need to change to benefit from a new standard, otherwise we develop a standard with the same requirements
- HL7 v3 RPS was unanimously agreed upon by ICH/M8 membership as the best choice for implementation in 2019 and the transition to another standard has been considered at multiple phases of v4 planning and implementation, and deemed impractical as it would add years and considerable cost to the introduction of a much-needed upgrade, which facilitates moving towards a data-centric approach

How will companies transition from eCTD v3.2.2 to v4.0?

- The transition process is described in the 'Forward Compatibility' section of the ICH IG and allows a seamless transition from v3.2.2 to v4.0 with an ongoing use of the v3.2.2 content (uniquely linking to v3.2.2 leafs via unique identifiers), when applicable

How is ICH supporting a transition from a document-centric to a data-centric approach for regulatory submissions?

- eCTD v4.0 is a more versatile messaging standard that can support the exchange of modern data standards or message formats, such as the following, which are currently being developed and implemented by ICH Work Groups:
 - An ICH M2/M8 EWG subgroup is working on a plan to support the incremental transition to a data-centric approach, such as the secure standardised technology platform for exchange of regulatory information between Sponsors and Regulators that is being proposed by [The Pharmaceutical Quality Knowledge Management \(PQKM\) Task Force](#)
 - A new ICH working group, Structured Product Quality Submissions (SPQS), is tasked with standardising product quality data
 - M11 Clinical electronic Structured Harmonised Protocol (CeSHarP) guideline will provide comprehensive clinical protocol organisation with standardised content
 - ICH Guidelines are reflecting the need for Real-world data and modern technology approaches (e.g., AI)

When will eCTD v4.0 be implemented in the M8 regions?

- All ICH M8 Member Regions are committed to implement eCTD v4.0, starting with a voluntary use, and after a transition period (varies by region), Regions may mandate submissions in eCTD v4.0 format
- It is planned to have an overlap of the implementation milestones (voluntary, mandatory) across the Regions
- There is always a chance that one Region will begin a mandatory use of eCTD v4.0 while others continue to fully implement it
- The implementation status timelines are posted on the [ICH M8 eCTD v4.0 webpage](#)

Is there a plan for non-M8 regions to adopt eCTD v4.0?

- For Countries/Regions that are considering/planning the implementation of eCTD, the ICH M8 IWG is strongly recommending going directly to eCTD v4.0, and not starting with implementation of eCTD v3.2.2
 - This mitigates the need to transition to v4.0
 - This reduces the time to implement v4.0

What is ICH M8 doing to address implementer questions?

- ICH M8 IWG has a [change request process](#) by which eCTD v4.0 implementers and industry partners can submit any questions or corrections to implementation specifications
- ICH M8 IWG has reestablished a standing eCTD Vendor group to support the implementation of eCTD v4.0. This includes providing a forum to share and discuss open questions and provide clear roadmaps for availability of eCTD v4.0 tools